Build a Provider Research File for Dad That Won't Go Stale

Four prompts to decide what would matter to your family, see what a recommended name actually tells you, learn the questions that make research useful, and start a file that says what to recheck later.

Where you are

Dad is managing well. A neighbor swears by one agency, your aunt has a facility in mind, and you have a vague sense you should be writing something down. There's no deadline, and that's the advantage.

This guide gives you four ChatGPT prompts to organize what you already know and to see what you don't know yet. It is preparation, not an assessment. Use only information you have permission to share, with names removed. The AI organizes and drafts; it does not diagnose, assess safety, or decide. Bring clinical questions to a clinician, and call emergency services for an emergency.

What you'll have at the end

You can say what your family would need from a provider, which questions turn a name into useful research, and which details will have to be checked again before anyone chooses.

A one-page Research File Starter: What would matter to our family, Questions to ask any provider, What we'll recheck before choosing, and a blank entry card with source and date.

Before you start

- Names anyone has mentioned, and who mentioned them.
- What you know about Dad's health and daily routine right now.
- Where the family lives and how far anyone could realistically travel. If you have only the names, that's a fine place to start.

PROMPT 1

Decide what would matter to your family

WHY THIS MATTERS

Without a short list of what matters, research turns into collecting. Location, family access, and Dad's stated preferences are a good start, even before his needs are known.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Where Dad lives, where the family lives, and anything he's said about help at home or moving.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is where my father lives, where the rest of us are, and what he's said about getting help or moving someday:

> [PASTE YOUR NOTES]
>
> Draft a list under three headings: WHAT WE KNOW MATTERS (location, access for family, things he's said he wants or won't accept), WHAT WILL MATTER BUT DEPENDS ON HIS FUTURE NEEDS, and WHAT WE HAVEN'T TALKED ABOUT YET. Write the third group as questions for a family conversation. Do not suggest a type of care, name a provider, or decide what he will need.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

Items in the first group you can act on today, and how many sit in the second.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Ask Dad about one item from the third group.

PROMPT 2

See what a recommended name actually tells you

WHY THIS MATTERS

A friend's warm recommendation is a reason to ask questions, not a conclusion. Writing down what you actually know about a name usually reveals that you know almost nothing that would help you compare.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The names you've been given, with the names replaced by letters, and what each person said about them.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> People have mentioned a few providers to us for my father someday. I've replaced the names with letters. Here is who mentioned each one and what they said:
>
> [PASTE YOUR NOTES, NAMES REMOVED]
>
> For each one, list: WHAT WE WERE TOLD, WHO TOLD US AND WHEN, WHAT THAT PERSON'S SITUATION WAS (if I said), and WHAT WE DON'T KNOW THAT WOULD MATTER FOR MY FATHER. Then note which of the things we were told are the kind that change over time. Do not look anything up, compare these providers, rate them, or tell me which to keep.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

The last column. It will be the longest, and that's useful.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Thank the person who recommended it, and ask them one question from the last column.

PROMPT 3

Learn the questions that make research useful

WHY THIS MATTERS

The difference between a name and a research entry is a set of needs-based questions with dated answers. Knowing the questions now means you won't be learning them under pressure later.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Your list from Prompt 1.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is what my family has decided would matter in a care provider for my father:
>
> [PASTE THE LIST FROM PROMPT 1]
>
> Write the questions a family would ask any provider, whether in-home or residential, to learn whether it could meet his needs, grouped as: WHAT THEY PROVIDE AND FOR WHOM, WHO IS ON DUTY ACROSS A DAY AND NIGHT, ROOMS AND DAILY LIFE, WHAT HAPPENS WHEN NEEDS CHANGE, and HOW FAMILY STAYS INVOLVED. Mark each question as ASK NOW (the answer is stable) or ASK AGAIN LATER (the answer expires). Do not answer any of them or describe what any particular provider offers.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

How many questions are marked ASK AGAIN LATER. That tells you how much of the file is temporary.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Choose the three ASK NOW questions you'd be comfortable asking on a casual visit.

PROMPT 4

Start the file

WHY THIS MATTERS

A good file is mostly structure: what matters, what to ask, what to recheck, and a card per provider with source and date. The names can wait.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The results of Prompts 1 to 3.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is what my family has gathered to start a provider research file for my father:
>
> [PASTE THE RESULTS OF PROMPTS 1 TO 3]
>
> Make a one-page Research File Starter with four parts: WHAT WOULD MATTER TO OUR FAMILY; QUESTIONS TO ASK ANY PROVIDER; WHAT WE'LL RECHECK BEFORE CHOOSING, with a suggested interval for each; and a blank ENTRY CARD with the fields Provider, Type of help, Who told us about them, Date, What they said, What we confirmed and when, and Still to ask. Leave the card blank. Do not add any provider names, ratings, or recommendations, and do not state anything about current availability or cost.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A file that would still make sense if you didn't open it for a year.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Fill in one entry card for the first name you were given, honestly, with the blanks left blank.

A research file needs a person at the center

The questions worth asking a provider come from Dad's situation, not from a brochure. The care interview captures that situation as a Family Care Profile, which is the file your research and your care consultant's advice will both refer back to.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›